

STAGE SEVEN • HARD SKILLS

# FIRSTS

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## DISCUSSION PROMPTS

*Open-ended questions to seed group conversation beyond the worksheets*

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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## FIRSTS • Discussion Prompts

*Stage Seven • Hard Skills*

### PURPOSE

Individual worksheets answer “what did you build, write, or analyze?” These prompts answer a different question: “what's your real, lived experience with the tools and processes this stage covers?” They're open-ended and personal, meant to seed conversation beyond a simple share-out of worksheet answers.

Matching this stage's Session Plan, prompts here are organized by sub-session (thirteen in total) rather than by section, with three prompts each — slightly fewer than other stages' four, given the sheer number of sub-sessions this stage requires.

As with every stage, these are meant to be read aloud and picked selectively — choose the one that feels most alive for the room rather than working through all three every time.

## Prompts by Sub-Session

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### SUB-SESSION 1A

#### Data & Analysis — First Half

*“What's a decision you've seen made based on bad or misread data? What went wrong?”*

*“How confident do you genuinely feel reading a spreadsheet cold, before this stage? Has that changed at all today?”*

*“What's the difference between a number that's technically correct and one that's actually useful?”*

### SUB-SESSION 1B

#### Data & Analysis — Second Half

*“What's a trend you've personally noticed in your own life or work that you never actually acted on?”*

*“Have you ever caught yourself trusting a statistic more than you should have, just because it was a number?”*

*“What's the hardest part of turning a data finding into a clear written recommendation?”*

### SUB-SESSION 2A

#### Documents & Written Communication — First Half

*“What's the best-written report or document you've ever read professionally or academically? What made it work?”*

*“Have you ever had a document's poor formatting undermine genuinely strong content?”*

*“What's your honest relationship with outlining before you write — do you skip it, and what happens when you do?”*

### SUB-SESSION 2B

#### Documents & Written Communication — Second Half

*“Has documentation someone else wrote ever genuinely saved you, or genuinely failed you?”*

*“What's the hardest part of writing for someone with less context than you have?”*

*“What's a research question you've asked that turned out to be way too broad to actually answer?”*

### SUB-SESSION 3A

#### Planning & Project Management — Foundations

*“What's a project that would have genuinely benefited from more upfront planning, in hindsight?”*

*“How do you personally know when a risk is worth planning for versus not worth worrying about?”*

*"What's your honest relationship with tracking logs — do you actually maintain them, or do they quietly lapse?"*

#### SUB-SESSION 3B

### Planning & Project Management — Execution

*"Has a small process improvement you proposed ever actually gotten implemented? What made it land?"*

*"What's a project you scoped too ambitiously and never finished? What would you scope differently now?"*

*"What's a workflow in your own life that's genuinely repetitive enough to be worth optimizing?"*

#### SUB-SESSION 3C

### Planning & Project Management — Full Execution & Closure

*"What's the difference between a project that felt finished and one that just stopped?"*

*"How do you personally decide which of several problems to tackle first when you're facing multiple at once?"*

*"What's a lesson from a past project you never actually wrote down, and have you had to relearn it since?"*

#### SUB-SESSION 4A

### Visual & Presentation Tools — First Half

*"What's the most memorable presentation slide you've ever seen, good or bad?"*

*"Have you ever chosen a chart type because it looked impressive rather than because it fit the data?"*

*"What's your honest reaction to watching yourself back on video? Has it changed at all with practice?"*

#### SUB-SESSION 4B

### Visual & Presentation Tools — Second Half

*"What's a technical idea you've struggled to explain to someone without your background?"*

*"What's currently in your portfolio that you're proud of, and what's missing that you know should be there?"*

*"What's held you back from sharing your work publicly, if anything?"*

#### SUB-SESSION 5A

### Digital Tools & Systems — First Half

*"What's a tool you were intimidated by at first that turned out to be genuinely easy once you tried it?"*

*"How organized is your current file system, honestly? What would someone else find if they had to look for something in it?"*

*"Is there a tool relevant to your target field you've been meaning to explore but haven't yet? What's stopped you?"*

#### SUB-SESSION 5B

### Digital Tools & Systems — Second Half

*"What's a repetitive task you do that you now realize could genuinely be automated?"*

*"Have you ever spent more time building a workaround than an existing integration would have taken to set up?"*

*"What's your honest estimate of how long a typical task takes you, and how confident are you in that estimate?"*

#### SUB-SESSION 6A

### Collaboration & Reflection — First Half

*"What's feedback you received during this stage that you initially resisted but came around to?"*

*"What's a cross-functional or cross-discipline conversation that taught you something genuinely unexpected?"*

*"Looking back across your reflections so far in this stage, what's a pattern you're noticing in your own growth?"*

#### SUB-SESSION 6B

### Collaboration & Reflection — Stage Close

*"Of everything covered in this entire ninety-FIRST stage, what's the one skill you're most confident applying right now?"*

*"What's a genuine learning gap you're leaving this stage with, and how do you feel about naming it honestly?"*

*"If you had to teach one FIRST from this stage to someone starting from scratch, which would you choose, and why?"*